PARTNERS of the AMERICAS
Connect • Serve • Change Lives

Coronavirus (COVID-19) Protocol and Policy for Travel and Work

March 10, 2020

In an effort to protect employees, their families, and the general population, the following policy and protocols **will be in effect immediately for Partners of the Americas (Partners) staff in the DC. office,** and remain in effect until updated evidence warrants changes in this policy:

1) **Effective immediately** and until further notice, Partners will review all work-related travel to determine risks associated with COVID-19. On a case-by-case basis, the President & CEO and the unit VP will approve each travel request. Where COVID-19 is considered to be widespread or we have other reasons to believe that the information or regional medical support systems are insufficient, travel will most likely be modified or suspended.

2) Until further notice, and pending approval as defined in #1, **Partners will be continuing to engage** with work-related travel to areas of limited risk of transmissions such as the countries in Latin America and the Caribbean**.**

3) ***Non-essential travel,*** defined as any travel which can reasonably be delayed, canceled, or performed remotely, should be assessed with your unit VP. If you have non-essential travel already booked, we can check the possibilities to cancel and seek refunds on expenses whenever possible.

4) This policy applies to travel by all forms of public transport (air, rail, buses, and other forms of public ground transportation). *At this point, It does not apply to your daily travel to and from the office in DC, or to local work events.*

5) **Partners will make work accommodations for staff considered as "People at Higher Risk and Special Populations," under** CDC regulations. For these two groups, Partners encourages working from home for safety matters. Supervisors must immediately be notified before a decision is made, and a Flex Work Arrangement (FWA) may be requested.
   - *People at Higher Risk* are older adults (60 years or older), and people with serious chronic and medical conditions such as heart disease, diabetes, and lung disease.
   - *Special Populations* include, but are not necessarily limited to, pregnant women, breastfeeding mothers, and children.

6) **For Field Staff (only) out of the United States:** please follow any guidance given by your local government; if more strict, your local guidelines should supersede Partners' guidance and policies in this matter.

7) For project-specific volunteers, contractors and sub-agreement entities, unit VPs should coordinate with our donors to determine applicability of these guidelines and agree upon any other donor-required guidelines / protocols.

8) **Partners is requesting employees to evaluate your personal travel plans for safety on any form of public transportation (air, rail, bus, etc.). Consideration should be taken when traveling to areas with multiple cases of COVID-19 confirmed.**
If you or any family member has personal travel to an area with confirmed COVID-19 cases, you should monitor your health for known symptoms of COVID-19. Please review: CDC: Symptoms of COVID-19. Additionally, you should follow the protocols for office safety and hygiene, as outlined below, and discuss with Human Resources whether or not you follow the **government quarantine policies.**

9) **Partners may be "stress-testing" our ability for all employees to work remotely if there was a COVID-19 outbreak in DC, and we were not able to leave our homes.** We may select two days (dates to be determined) when all employees will be required to stay home and work remotely. This will allow us to assess how our business infrastructure withstands this test to provide business continuity, and whether there are areas we need to reinforce should the situation arise.

10) **Partners is committed to making work accommodations** to any staff who needs assistance regardless of symptoms. If you have safety/health concerns about coming to the office, please contact the Human Resource at rtorres@partners.net.

For further information, your main resources for information should include the World Health Organization (WHO), the Center for Disease Control (CDC) and the Office of Personnel Management (OPM).

Protocols for office safety and hygiene:

- Have your flu shot vaccine up to date:
- For people aged over 55 years old and/or having a chronic disease, vaccination against **pneumococcal** infections is also recommended.
- Wash your hands more often with soap for at least 20 seconds, especially in a collective environment, before/after eating, before/after using the toilet.
- Use a hand sanitizer that contains minimum 60% alcohol.
- Sneeze and cough into tissues, throw the tissue away and wash your hands immediately. If you get mucus or saliva on your skin, clean it off right away.
- Regularly and thoroughly clean and disinfect objects and surfaces you work with/on.
- Avoid touching your face with unwashed hands, especially eyes, nose, or mouth.
- Avoid close contact with people who are sick, especially people exhibiting respiratory symptoms and fever.
- Avoid handshakes, kisses, physical contact in collective environments (bus, metro, carpooling, etc.).
- The Executive Administrative Office will display awareness and educational materials for Cleaning Protocols at strategic locations in the office to promote regular and appropriate hygiene to all employees, consultants, interns, volunteers, and visitors. This also includes regular cleaning (twice a day is recommended) using soap/antiseptic cleanser or surfaces

likely to come in human contact such as kitchen areas, tables and chairs in common areas, door handles, shared keyboards, and the like.

- Partners office is committed to promoting good respiratory hygiene in the workplace by providing paper tissues/Kleenex, for those who develop a runny nose or cough at work, along with closed bins for hygienically disposing of them.

We request working remotely (from home) when sick with any type of illness (cough, cold, fever, flu, etc.), or if necessary, take sick leave (SL). We also strongly encourage you to avoid taking public transportation if possible and attending large gatherings to reduce your risk of contracting the virus.

Partners is evaluating the situation based on safe evidence available and the overall objective to protect humanity. Additional guidelines to consider when scheduling or attending work-related meetings:

- **Critical**: How critical is the travel/meeting to our operations? If canceled or postponed, would it lead to a substantial halt in our programs or to essential elements of our programming? Would it reduce program performance considerably? Would it have an immediate and significant impact on our business development efforts?
- **Continuity**: Would canceling or postponing this trip/meeting cease operational continuity? Would canceling or postponing this trip be a program stopped
- **Inter-dependency**: Would canceling or postponing this meeting have an immediate and substantial impact on the work of others?
- **Redundancy or Replicability**: Can you replicate what you need to do on this trip/meeting in another way? Is there someone else in the location that can undertake the work?
- **Remote Meeting an Option**: Can you replace this trip/meeting with a remote working arrangement? Does the infrastructure in the locale (e.g., Internet access, etc.) facilitate this?

Protocols for Staff in Contact with an infected person/staff diagnosed or suspect infection with COVID 19

1) Staff who have been in contact with someone diagnosed with COVID 19, or with someone where there is a reasonable suspicion of infection, **should self-isolate under CDC and WHO guidelines**. They are not to attend work at Partners offices; and shall notify their supervisor immediately. *This information will be kept confidential.*

2) Staff diagnosed with COVID 19 or who present any symptoms of infection should self-isolate. They are not to attend work at Partners offices and shall notify their supervisor immediately. *This information will be kept confidential.*

3) For staff having at least two (2) of the following symptoms (cough, shortness of breath, or low or high fever), **while traveling or residing in a city with a confirmed case, OR after contact or suspected** contact with a confirmed or suspected case:

a) **Don't go to work:** notify their supervisor immediately.
b) Contact your health care provider ***by phone*** and explain your symptoms and seek their advice on testing. Testing kits for COVID-19 are not yet widely available and may require a physician's authorization. If you are having severe respiratory or coughing symptoms, and need emergency care, ***please call 911***, or phone the emergency department ahead of time, so they can prepare to protect other patients, prior to your arrival, as well as to provide advice on seeking care in their facility.
c) Avoid any contact with your family and friends (kissing, hugging, close contacts, etc.), avoid confined spaces, and follow local government quarantine policies.

We sincerely appreciate your cooperation and ask that every staff think creatively and proactively about how they can safely fulfill Partners' mission during this challenging time. This is a fluid situation, and we realize you may have questions, so please do not hesitate to contact the Executive Administrative Office| Human Resources at rtorres@partners.net at any time.